

Wednesday, 19 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Light rain

24° 16°

BIRMINGHAM

Heavy drizzle

22° 15°

MANCHESTER

Light rain

20° 14°

GLASGOW

Light drizzle

16° 13°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1

The Prime Minister has communicated with a person posing as Susie Wiles, the chief of staff to Donald Trump.

It's emerged that the PM was caught in a hoax message exchange. Further details are expected to come out throughout the day.

POLITICS · UK

2

A Serco employee has been charged with misconduct in public office after allegedly sharing asylum seeker addresses.

The 62-year-old man is due to appear before magistrates. The charges relate to the sharing of addresses in Thetford.

CRIME · UK

3

The state-owned Ferguson shipyard on the Clyde is set to cut a quarter of its workforce.

Seventy of its 283 staff will lose their jobs through a voluntary redundancy process. This comes amidst ongoing challenges for the shipyard.

ECONOMY · UK

4

Disabled people in England are set to receive 24-hour free bus travel from next April.

The change has been welcomed by campaign groups. It aims to improve accessibility and independence for many.

SOCIAL · UK

5

Former workers at a new £400m prison have described a 'chaotic atmosphere' due to under-staffing and inadequate training.

Concerns have been raised about the operational readiness of the facility. This follows reports of issues at other new prisons.

JUSTICE · UK

What's coming up

1 **The National Television Awards have made history with their first ever all-female shortlist for the drama acting award.**

The five talented actresses vying for the coveted prize are Ella Bruccoleri, Sheridan Smith, Ruth Jones, Vicky McClure, and Judy Parfitt. It's a fantastic recognition of female talent in British drama.

ON AIR – Who do you think deserves to win this year?

AWARDS · COMING UP

2 **Kanye West has announced a series of tour dates in Russia, marking a significant return for a major Western artist.**

This would be the first time a major Western artist has played Russia since the invasion of Ukraine. The announcement has certainly sparked a lot of conversation.

ON AIR – Do you think this signals a shift in cultural relations?

MUSIC · COMING UP

3 **Noise concerns have been raised over Reading Festival's plans for a music extension later this month.**

Charli XCX, rapper Dave, and Chase & Status are set to headline the festival. Local residents are worried about the potential impact of extended music hours.

ON AIR – Are you heading to Reading Festival, and what are your thoughts on extended music hours at festivals?

MUSIC · COMING UP

4 **The festive specials for 'Mrs Brown's Boys' have been cancelled this year after one of the stars broke their jaw.**

The sitcom's creator says immediate surgery is required for the injured cast member. Fans will be disappointed, but there's hope the show will return in 2027.

ON AIR – Will you miss your annual dose of Mrs Brown's Boys this Christmas?

TV · COMING UP

5 **Earl Spencer is set to 'tell the truth' about his sister Princess Diana in a new book, 'Swan Song: Diana, My Sister'.**

The book is due to be released in the UK next month, nearly 30 years after her passing. It promises to offer a unique and personal perspective on her life.

ON AIR – What are your memories of Princess Diana, and will you be reading this new book?

BOOKS · COMING UP

On the schedule

1 **Sheffield United's owners are facing a winding-up order in the High Court today, which could have serious consequences for the club.**

The High Court hearing could lead to a range of outcomes, including a potential 12-point deduction for the Championship club. It's a very anxious time for Blades fans.

ON AIR – How much do these off-field issues affect a team's performance on the pitch?

FOOTBALL · UK

2 **Harry Kane is reportedly ready to begin discussions over a new contract with Bayern Munich.**

The England captain has had a fantastic start to his career in Germany, leading the Bundesliga champions. This news will be welcomed by Bayern fans.

ON AIR – Do you think Harry Kane made the right move to Bayern Munich?

FOOTBALL · EUROPE

3 **Former Arsenal and France captain Patrick Vieira has been appointed as the new head coach of the Senegal men's national team.**

Vieira brings a wealth of experience from his playing and managerial career. He'll be hoping to lead Senegal to further success.

ON AIR – Do you think Patrick Vieira is a good fit for the Senegal national team?

FOOTBALL · INTERNATIONAL

4 **Great Britain's Amy Hunt has had a 'sensational' European Championships, winning four gold medals.**

She secured victories in the women's 100m, 200m, 4×100m relay, and the mixed 4×100m relay. It's been an iconic performance from the sprinter.

ON AIR – What an incredible achievement! Where do you think Amy Hunt ranks among Britain's top athletes right now?

ATHLETICS · UK

5 **The Premier League is set to publish the verdicts of its Key Match Incidents Panel for the first time this season.**

This means fans will get to see the official judgements on controversial referee and VAR decisions. It's a move towards greater transparency in the game.

ON AIR – Do you think this increased transparency will help or hinder the debate around refereeing decisions?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A heartwarming trend sees people embracing the art of 'upcycling old furniture' to give it a new lease of life.**
Instead of buying new, many are transforming worn-out chairs, tables, and dressers into stylish, unique pieces for their homes, often with surprisingly creative results.
- 2 New research suggests that 'spending time near water', like rivers or the seaside, can significantly boost mood.**
Whether it's the gentle sound of waves or the calming ripple of a stream, studies indicate that 'blue spaces' have a profound positive effect on our well-being.
- 3 The delightful hobby of 'creating miniature gardens' in teacups or terrariums is charming enthusiasts.**
These tiny landscapes, often featuring small plants and intricate decorations, offer a peaceful, creative escape and a touch of green magic for any home.
- 4 A fascinating study reveals that 'listening to the sounds of a crackling fire' can have a deeply relaxing effect.**
The natural rhythm and warmth associated with a fire, even just the audio, can reduce stress and promote a sense of calm and cosiness.
- 5 The simple pleasure of 'writing postcards to friends and family' is making a lovely comeback.**
In an age of instant messages, a handwritten postcard arriving through the letterbox feels special and personal, bringing a smile to both sender and receiver.
- 6 A charming movement encourages people to 'swap homegrown produce' with neighbours and local communities.**
Gardeners are sharing their excess fruit, vegetables, and herbs, fostering community spirit and reducing food waste in a delicious way.
- 7 Research indicates that 'taking a mindful walk in a local park' can improve focus and creativity.**
Paying attention to the sights, sounds, and smells of nature, even in an urban park, helps to clear the mind and spark new ideas.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to quickly judge the temperature outside, even if it's just peeking through a window?

ANSWER: ...STICKING JUST ONE FINGER OUT THE DOOR OR WINDOW TO GET A QUICK FEEL FOR IT!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before settling down to watch their favourite TV programme?

ANSWER: ...MAKING SURE ALL THE CUSHIONS ON THE SOFA ARE PERFECTLY PLUMPED AND ALIGNED!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes a 'particular smell' just instantly takes you back to a specific memory or a moment in time?**
Whether it's freshly cut grass, a certain type of food, or a familiar perfume, what's a smell that instantly transports you, and what memory does it bring back?
- **We all have those 'little everyday objects' that we couldn't do without, even if they seem insignificant to others, don't we?**
Perhaps it's a favourite mug, a specific pen, or a lucky charm. What's that small, everyday item that you simply can't live without?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Weather.** It once 'rained fish' in a small town in Honduras, a phenomenon reported annually for over a century.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The world's largest rubber duck once sailed the River Thames as part of a quirky art installation.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The total weight of all the ants on Earth is estimated to be equal to the total weight of all the humans on Earth.
- A group of flamingos is called a 'flamboyance'.
- Bananas are technically berries, while strawberries are not.
- The Great Wall of China is not visible from space with the naked eye.
- The human heart can create enough pressure to squirt blood 30 feet.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar on August 27, 1896, lasting only 38 minutes.
- Octopuses have three hearts: two pump blood through the gills, and one circulates it to the rest of the body.
- Chameleons change their colour not only to blend in but also to communicate and regulate their body temperature.

On this day

Day 231 of the year, 134 days left in 2026. Today Afghan Independence Day, commemorates the Treaty of Rawalpindi in 1919, granting independence from Britain (Afghanistan); August Revolution Commemoration Day (Vietnam); Birthday of Crown Princess Mette-Marit (Norway); Christian Feast Day: Bertulf of Bobbio. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1989 — Romeo Miller, American basketball player, rapper, actor
- 1980 — Darius Campbell, Scottish singer-songwriter, guitarist, and actor (died 2022)
- 1984 — Ryan Taylor, English footballer
- 1946 — Dawn Steel, American film producer (died 1997)
- 1952 — Jonathan Frakes, American actor and director
- 1975 — Tracie Thoms, American actress
- 1951 — John Deacon, English bass player and songwriter
- 1969 — Nate Dogg, American rapper (died 2011)

THE DAY TODAY

- 1981 — Gulf of Sidra Incident: United States F-14A Tomcat fighters intercept and shoot down two Libyan Sukhoi Su-22 fighter jets over the Gulf of Sidra.
- 2009 — A series of bombings in Baghdad, Iraq, kills 101 and injures 565 others.
- 2010 — Operation Iraqi Freedom ends, with the last of the United States brigade combat teams crossing the border to Kuwait.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1953 — Cold War: The CIA and MI6 help to overthrow the government of Mohammad Mosaddegh in Iran and reinstate the Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi.
- 1955 — In the Northeast United States, severe flooding caused by Hurricane Diane, claims 200 lives.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2010 — Operation Iraqi Freedom ends, with the last of the United States brigade combat teams crossing the border to Kuwait.
- 2017 — Tens of thousands of farmed non-native Atlantic salmon are accidentally released into the wild in Washington waters in the 2017 Cypress Island Atlantic salmon pen break.

- 1999 — In Belgrade, Yugoslavia, tens of thousands of Serbians rally to demand the resignation of Federal Republic of Yugoslavia President Slobodan Milošević.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 232 of the year, 133 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Amadour; Christian feast day: Bernard of Clairvaux; Christian feast day: Blessed Georg Häfner; Christian feast day: Heliodorus of Bet Zabdai. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1971 — David Walliams, English comedian, actor, and author
- 1948 — Robert Plant, English singer-songwriter
- 1934 — Tom Mangold, German-English journalist and author
- 1949 — Phil Lynott, Irish singer-songwriter, bass player, and producer (died 1986)
- 1992 — Alex Newell, American actor and singer
- 1981 — Ben Barnes, English actor
- 1992 — Demi Lovato, American singer-songwriter and actress
- 1971 — Ke Huy Quan, Vietnamese-American actor

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1975 — Viking program: NASA launches the Viking 1 planetary probe toward Mars.
- 1975 — ČSA Flight 540 crashes on approach to Damascus International Airport in Damascus, Syria, killing 126 people.
- 2007 — China Airlines Flight 120 catches fire and explodes after landing at Naha Airport in Okinawa, Japan.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1905 — Sun Yat-sen, Song Jiaoren, and others establish the Tongmenghui, a Republican, anti-Qing revolutionary organisation, in Tokyo, Japan.
- 1977 — Voyager program: NASA launches the Voyager 2 spacecraft.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

22–23

Belgian Grand Prix (F1)